STONEWARD CONSTRUCTION
Utah's ADU Experts

LICENSED UTAH CONTRACTOR
LICENSE #14271611-5501 (R100)

10 Steps to Building a Backyard ADU in Utah

A plain-language guide to Utah's new detached ADU law, what a project really costs, and how a factory-built home gets from your lot to move-in.

Updated November 2026. Planning information, not legal, tax or financial advice. Rules and prices change, so confirm current details with your city and in your written contract.

Why now: Utah's SB 284

Since October 1, 2026, larger Utah cities must allow a detached accessory dwelling unit (a separate small home in the backyard) as a permitted use on a lot of **11,000 square feet or more** that has a single-family home on it. In a primarily residential zone the city cannot require a conditional use permit. It cannot require more than one parking space for a unit under 650 square feet, or more than two for a unit of 650 square feet or more. Cities must also offer a way to convert a legally built outbuilding.

Your city can still set size, height, setback, owner-occupancy and rental rules, require a 90-day minimum rental, and limit you to one ADU per lot. So the details depend on where you live. See your city's page at **stonewardconstruction.com/utah-adu-cities**.

1 Check your lot

Start with the facts you can look up in ten minutes: your lot size (it needs to be at least 11,000 square feet for the state rule to apply), your zone, any HOA or covenants, and where the house, garage and utilities sit. Private HOA rules are separate from city rules, so read them before you spend money on drawings.

2 Learn your city's rules

Look for footprint and height limits, setbacks, how much of the yard accessory buildings can cover, parking, and whether you must live on the property. As an example, American Fork's rules adopted September 22, 2026 allow a footprint up to 1,500 square feet or the main home's footprint (whichever is smaller), a height of no more than 24 feet, 12-foot setbacks on most sides, and a 25 percent cap on accessory buildings in the rear yard. Your city will differ.

3 Decide what it is for

A suite for a parent, a long-term rental, or a home office each points to a different size and layout. Rentals have to be 90 days or longer in cities that choose that rule. Be honest about the plan, because it drives the budget.

4 Budget the whole project

The home is only part of the cost. Starting prices below are planning estimates for the home delivered and set on your foundation in Utah. They do not include site work, foundation, utility connections, the finish work that joins the modules, tax, permits or fees.

Cabana 200, 200 sq ft studio	**from $65,800**
Cabana 400, 397 sq ft one-bedroom	**from $118,700**
Mysa 500, 497 sq ft one-bedroom	**from $138,100**
Cabana 2 Bed, 638 sq ft two-bedroom	**from $171,200**
Torrey Flats, 696 sq ft	**from $188,500**
Rabbit 800, 800 sq ft two-story	**from $226,800**
Morada 1000, 1,000 sq ft single-story	**from $244,700**

Designer Series pricing as of November 2026. Other finish series cost somewhat more. Final price is confirmed in a written contract after design and preconstruction.

> **Typical ranges for the rest of the budget** (your lot will differ): crawl-space foundation $15 to $40 per square foot; driveway and flatwork $8 to $12 per square foot; utility connections $5,000 to $30,000 depending on how far sewer, water and power are from the new unit; finish work to join the modules $15 to $50 per module square foot; plus a 10 percent contingency. Utilities are often the biggest surprise, so we price them line by line before you commit.

5 Line up financing

Homeowners pay cash, use a home equity loan or line of credit, a cash-out refinance, or a construction loan. A modular home on a permanent foundation is generally treated like a site-built home, but your lender decides. Talk to a lender early, because construction loans pay out in stages. Stoneward is not a lender and cannot promise approval, rates or terms.

6 Choose a plan and finishes

There are 33 plans, from a 200 square foot studio to a family home, and four finish series (Designer, Modern, Rustic and Balance). Smaller plans are easier to fit inside setbacks, and a unit under 650 square feet needs at most one parking space.

7 Confirm the site

Check how far sewer, water and power are from where the unit will sit, and how a crane and a delivery truck will reach it. You do not need to build a crane pad. The crane usually sets up in the street or driveway, on mats if the ground is soft. What matters is reach, clear access, and no overhead power lines in the way.

8 Permits and approvals

Your city reviews the site plan and plans and issues the building permit. The factory handles state approvals for the home itself. Allow time for city review, and ask the city which departments sign off.

9 Build while the site gets ready

Once the contract is signed, the home is built indoors in a factory (a regular-size home typically takes about 8 to 10 weeks of construction) while your foundation, utilities and site work happen on your lot. Expect a deposit, staged payments during the factory build, and final payments before delivery.

10 Delivery, set and finish

On set day the modules arrive by truck and a crane places them on the foundation. Then the seams are joined, plumbing, electrical and heating are connected and tested, and the finish work is completed, followed by inspections and your certificate of occupancy.

> **What Stoneward does.** I'm Nate Baird, a licensed Utah general contractor in American Fork with a mortgage financing background. I do the lot review, the permits, the foundation and site work, set day and finish, so you have one person to call. Send your address and we will check your lot size, your city's rules and the delivery route, then tell you straight whether a detached ADU fits.

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